

DOES ANYONE KNOW PENGUIN CPR?

How you killed Linux, and other non-fiction

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Few concepts in the digital world can hold a candle against open source, when it comes to public sentiment. However, if the real world teaches you one thing, it is that sentiment doesn't always get you great success. Linux, when it was born, created this huge buzz. After all, who wouldn't love something (or someone) that thumbed its nose at the big boys. Even if we use their products, most of us seem to hate large corporations. There's just something irritating about hearing money figures in billions, while you slog like a dog to afford what little standard of living you can afford. That's what Linux was, a breath of fresh air, someone wanting to give you something for free, which other companies were charging an arm and a leg for.

The free ride

The biggest pull to Linux was the fact that it was free – there's no two ways about that. However, the free that the developers were aiming for was the free that's bereft of ownership, whilst all we users saw was free as in zero cost. The disconnect in the driving force between the customer and the supplier is perhaps why Linux isn't the biggest OS in the world today. Nobody imagined

that a group of amateur hackers, however skilled they might have been, could produce a full fledged multi-tasking operating system, that could hold its own against the glitzy offerings from the big corporations. Linus Torvalds and his men did much more than that. They built the entire kernel from scratch, somehow bypassing Brooks' Law (see box), and also provided an admirable amount of supporting resources.

Why free rides go empty sometimes

A lot (and we mean A LOT) of hard work went into making Linux, however, as has been admitted by some original team members, it was accompanied by minimal planning. The structure to Linux was flawed in two very important ways. First, subsequent improvements to the product would be difficult. Secondly, because of the lack of a

